As a tape ball is not as hard as a regular cricket ball, you don't have to pad up, and most windows, street lamps and cars that the ball makes contact with – and it always does – *usually* remain intact. In many ways, tape-ball cricket is the urban cricket fanatic's natural counter-strategy to the lack of proper playing facilities in all major cities of Pakistan. However, every once in a while, you end up with a very angry neighbour with a broken window or a dented bonnet. That's when you have to execute a very good exit plan.

And what if the batsman gets hit on the face or the chest? Well, it doesn't hurt much. A Pathan can certainly take it. Tape chisels your teeth. When you combine the wildly swinging tape ball with the mean streets of central Karachi, where buildings and apartment blocks surround players – creating handicap spots, so you can only score a six over long-on, not long-off, or can only pull over mid-on, not square-leg – your mind develops the ability to work through the gaps like a sniper, not a batsman. It's thrilling to bat on tape. (Till his retirement, Younis Khan practised with a tape ball, shaving it off from half of the ball to play against its consistently crazy swing.)

But this sort of cricket hurts our bowlers. The correct line and length for bowling tape balls is different from the cricket ball. Since it is lighter in weight, one needs to exert more elbow grease while bowling. If you try too hard, you may end up injuring yourself – a common phenomenon. This is possibly why the better bowlers emerge from the Punjab and the northwest. The sprawling landscape, open spaces and parks there allow more room for conventional cricket, unlike the tape-ball cricket in the congested streets of Karachi.

As for the cricket formats we played, there were not a lot to choose from at the time. Even U-14 kids had to play 50-over games. Twenty20 cricket didn't officially exist under the International Cricket Council (ICC) during my growing-up years, but it was fairly common in Karachi's 'Ramadan cricket' circuit. The format is much older and, yes, I can claim that T20 was first invented and played in Karachi during those famous night tournaments held in the city during Ramadan, a time of the year when you can't really play during the day because of the scorching heat and the sixteen hours of fasting.

In fact, in the '90s, T20 cricket was a special 'only-during-Ramadan' feature of the Karachi cricket scene, an annual festival of sorts in the 'City of Lights', as we call it. With a political shake-up happening in the city, gang violence on the rise and stadiums being shutdown or usurped by encroachers, street cricket was the healthiest form of recreation a young man could indulge in. Night cricket and its informal T20 tournaments are a part of the Karachi cricket cult that only a hardcore Karachiite can claim to know of.

They say that necessity is the mother of invention. Indeed, tape-ball cricket is one such invention from Karachi. The urban jungle we grew up in didn't – and still doesn't – have many cricket grounds; streets, even alleys, therefore serve as proxy playing areas. At any given time of the day, there are all sorts of tape-ball tournaments going on: Apartment Building A versus Apartment Building B, Street 1 versus Street 2, Block X versus Block Y and, of course, at the club versus club level. Although born in Karachi, tape-ball cricket is now quite common in other parts of the country, even the world. In Pakistan, however, it has significantly changed the way cricket is played.

For those of my generation who have grown up on it, tape-ball cricket has created a new breed of cricketers who can do wonders with the ball and bat because of the extra responsiveness the